YOUR COMPLETE GUIDE

Home Buyer's Guide



Everything you need to know to find, finance, and close on the home of your dreams — with an expert by your side every step of the way.

Mathew Smith & Khristi V Cummings

SMITH & CUMMINGS REALTORS · UNITED REAL ESTATE GALLERY

(904) 334-2295
Direct Line

904MattSmith@gmail.com
Email

1262-1 S McDuff Avenue
Jacksonville, FL 32205

United Real Estate Gallery

WELCOME

A Personal Note From Mathew & Khristi



Congratulations on taking the first step.

Buying a home is one of the biggest investments and financial decisions you'll ever make. While it's a major commitment, it's also one of the most exciting milestones of your life — and we're proud to be part of that journey with you.

Home buying is a detailed process, and we'll be working hard to make every step as smooth and rewarding as possible. Our job is to guide you, protect your interests, and make sure your needs are fully met from the first showing all the way through to handing you the keys.

This guide was designed to walk you through every stage of the home buying process so you can feel confident, make informed decisions, and act as an educated buyer. It will also help all of us understand exactly what you're looking for so our search is as efficient as possible.

Please review all the information carefully. Every transaction is unique, so please never hesitate to ask us anything along the way — that's exactly what we're here for.



Mathew Smith & Khristi V Cummings
REALTORS® · SMITH & CUMMINGS REALTORS · UNITED REAL ESTATE GALLERY

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CHAPTER ONE

Preliminary Financing: How Much Home Can You Buy?

01
ESTIMATE YOUR BUDGET

Lenders recommend your total monthly debt payments be no more than 43% of your monthly gross income. Use an online mortgage calculator to estimate buying power based on your income, current debts, and today's rates.

02
REVIEW YOUR CREDIT SCORE

Your credit score is one of the primary factors a lender uses to determine your interest rate. The better your credit, the better your lending terms. Obtain your reports from all three agencies: Equifax, TransUnion, and Experian.

03
GATHER DOCUMENTS

These documents help establish your debt-to-income ratio and borrowing ability. Gather everything before meeting with a lender to speed up the process.

04
TALK TO A LENDER

After reviewing your own finances, speak with a qualified lender. They'll give you an accurate picture of what you can afford and explain the loan options best suited to your unique financial situation.

Poor	Fair	Good	Very Good	Exceptional
< 580	580–669	670–739	740–799	800+

REQUIRED DOCUMENTS CHECKLIST

- Federal / Social Security Number
- Federal Tax Returns (2 Years)
- W-2 Forms from Prior 2 Years
- Complete Record of Assets
- Pay Stubs (Most Recent Month)
- Stock / Bond / Investment Accounts
- Employment History Summary
- IRA / Retirement Plan Statements
- Bank Statements (2–3 Months)
- Life Insurance Policies
- Creditor Info (Auto, Student, Credit Cards)
- Gift Letters (if applicable)

Pro Tip: Avoid major purchases, job changes, or new credit accounts in the months before applying for a mortgage. These can negatively affect your score and qualification status.

CHAPTER TWO

Know Your Mortgage

Loan Types

FIXED RATE TRADITIONAL LOAN

These loans are offered with repayment terms of 15–30 years. The lender agrees to charge a fixed interest rate for the life of the loan, meaning your monthly mortgage payment stays the same for the full term.

ADJUSTABLE RATE LOANS (ARMS)

ARMs offer a lower rate for an initial period, then adjust based on market conditions. Rate changes happen at set intervals and the lender establishes both a maximum and minimum on fluctuations.

FHA LOANS

Federally insured loans made by private institutions. Borrowers may be able to put as little as 3.5% down. FHA insures a portion of the loan value to protect the lender.

VA GUARANTEED LOANS

Available to qualified veterans and their spouses. The VA does not require a down payment and allows borrowers to receive competitive interest rates through private lenders.

Know Your Lender

Home loans are available through commercial banks, mortgage companies, credit unions, and mortgage brokers. A broker doesn't lend money directly — they find a lender and secure the terms of your arrangement.

Broker vs. Traditional Lender: A broker may have access to several lenders and can offer a wider selection of loan products. However, a broker is not obligated to find you the absolute best deal — ask questions and compare.

Know Your Fees

- **Points:** 1 point = 1% of the loan amount, often tied to the interest rate
- **Origination Fee:** Charged by the lender for processing the loan
- **Underwriting Fee:** To investigate your creditworthiness
- **Broker Fee:** In addition to the origination fee, if using a broker
- **Transaction/Settlement Costs:** Appraisal, title, attorney, recording, notary fees

The government requires lenders to provide a **Loan Estimate** within 3 days of application and a **Closing Disclosure** no later than 3 days before closing. Review both carefully.

LENDER INTERVIEW CHEAT SHEET

- What loan types do you offer?
- Is the rate you're quoting the lowest for today?

- What is the Annual Percentage Rate (APR)?
- What are the discount points and origination fees?
- Can you lock in the rate? What's the fee?
- What's the total cost of the mortgage?
- Is the rate fixed or adjustable?
- What is the required down payment?
- Is mortgage insurance (PMI) required?
- Is there a prepayment penalty?

CHAPTER THREE

Pre-Approval vs. Pre-Qualification

Before you begin your home search in earnest, we highly recommend getting pre-approved for a mortgage. Pre-approved buyers are ahead in the home buying game — it gives you a significant edge when multiple offers have been made on a home.

Pre-Qualification

Only a loan agent's opinion that you'll be able to obtain financing. No verification is made and no formal approval is issued. It's a starting point — not a commitment.

- Quick and informal
- No credit pull required
- Not accepted by most sellers
- Based on stated income only

Pre-Approval ★

Your loan application has been through a rigorous procedure including a full review of your credit report. Pre-approval tells you exactly what homes you can afford and strengthens every offer you make.

- Full credit review completed
- Income and assets verified
- Accepted and preferred by sellers
- Typically closes faster

WHY PRE-APPROVAL MATTERS

If you make an offer on a home and then apply for a loan instead of the other way around, you're at the mercy of the lender — who now knows you don't have time to shop around. Pre-approved buyers generally close faster since most of the paperwork has already been taken care of, and sellers take your offer far more seriously.

You'll be in the best negotiating position when: You have been pre-approved for a mortgage · You are not simultaneously selling another home · You have kept your offer clean with minimal contingencies.

CHAPTER FOUR

Which Home Is the Right Home?

We've made it a rule to help identify a home that suits your wants, needs, and lifestyle. But it's worth drawing up and considering the kinds of things you're really looking for — it saves a lot of time and helps us avoid homes that are clearly off-target.

DEFINE YOUR MUST-HAVES VS. NICE-TO-HAVES

FEATURE	YOUR REQUIREMENTS	PRIORITY (MUST / PREFER / BONUS)
Price Range		
Location / Community		
Home Type		
Lot / Property Size		
Bedrooms		
Bathrooms		
Square Footage		
Interior Features		
Exterior Features		
School District		
Commute / Proximity		

No home will check every box perfectly — that's normal. The goal is to identify your **non-negotiables** versus what you're flexible on so we can make smart decisions quickly when the right property appears.

CHAPTER FIVE

Let the Showings Begin

The median number of homes a buyer views before choosing is 10. Home shopping can be both exciting and exhausting — preparation will keep you focused. We'll compile a list of the properties you've found online along with similar options from the MLS and start visiting them in person.

TIPS FOR VIEWING HOMES

- Don't try to view too many properties in one day
- Don't be put off by interior décor — it can always be changed
- Bring a notebook and take photos at each showing
- Keep a folder with printouts on each property you visit
- If you like a home, plan a second visit at a different time of day
- Never hesitate to ask questions — that's what we're here for

QUESTIONS TO ASK ABOUT ANY HOME

- When was the home built? How many owners?
- What did the current owner pay, and when?
- How does the price compare to similar nearby homes?
- Are the appliances included in the sale?
- What improvements has the owner made?
- What are the annual property taxes?
- Will taxes increase with deed transfer?
- Is there a builder's warranty?

QUESTIONS ABOUT SYSTEMS & STRUCTURE

- What is the age and condition of the plumbing, electrical, HVAC, and roof?
- What type of fuel is the home heated with?
- What are the average monthly utility costs?
- Is there adequate insulation?
- Are there any structural anomalies or exterior issues?

Remember: A professional home inspection will be necessary to fully answer most structural and mechanical questions. Never waive your inspection contingency.

CHAPTER SIX

Making an Offer

When you've found the home you want, it's time to make an offer. As your buyer's agents, we'll draft a contract with your offering price and the necessary contingencies. Review every detail carefully — if accepted by the seller, this becomes a legally binding agreement.

WHAT AN OFFER INCLUDES

- Offering price
- Earnest money deposit (typically ~1% of purchase price)
- Financing contingency
- Inspection contingency
- Proposed closing and possession dates
- Items included / excluded in the sale
- Pre-approval letter from your lender

Your earnest money is not at risk as long as you don't default on your contract. It's credited toward the purchase price at closing.

AFTER SUBMITTING

The seller will respond in one of three ways:

- Accept your offer as-is
- Reject your offer
- Issue a counter-offer

Counter-offers typically modify the purchase price, closing date, possession date, or inclusions. Be prepared for negotiations to go back and forth before both parties agree. In competitive markets, you may also be competing with other buyers.

Once both parties sign the accepted offer, you're under a legally binding contract.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Getting to the Finish Line

01
HOME INSPECTION

A professional inspector evaluates the physical condition of the property — structure, roof, electrical, plumbing, HVAC, insulation, and more. Based on findings, you may renegotiate, request repairs, or walk away.

02
CLEAR TITLE

An attorney or title specialist conducts a title examination to discover any issues that could prevent a clear transfer of ownership. Title insurance protects you and your heirs against past defects for as long as you own the home.

03
APPRAISAL

A qualified appraiser estimates the property's value. Your lender uses this to confirm the home is worth what you're borrowing. If the appraisal comes in low, the contract may need to be renegotiated.

04
CLOSING DAY

Once all contingencies are cleared, it's time to close! You'll review and sign the Closing Disclosure, conduct a final walk-through, bring certified funds, and receive the keys to your new home.

CLOSING PREPARATION CHECKLIST

- › Obtain homeowner's insurance and provide info to your lender
- › Review the Closing Disclosure form (provided 3 days before closing)
- › Confirm the exact dollar amount needed for closing with your settlement agent
- › Conduct a final walk-through to confirm the home's condition and that agreed repairs are complete
- › Arrange certified funds / wire transfer for closing day
- › Bring valid government-issued photo ID

Inspection Options: After receiving the inspection report, you can — get out of the contract if major issues are discovered · renegotiate the purchase price · negotiate that repairs be made by the seller before closing.

APPENDIX

Preferred Partners

Over the years we've built relationships with trusted local professionals whose work we stand behind. These are the people we call when our own clients need expert, reliable service.

PHOTOGRAPHY

REAL ESTATE PHOTOGRAPHY

The Listing Edge

1 (904) 994-9176

info@listingedge.net

COMING SOON

COMING SOON

INSPECTIONS

HOME INSPECTOR

Mr. House Inspectors

(904) 673-3430

mrhouseinspectors@gmail.com

COMING SOON

COMING SOON

APPRAISALS & SURVEYS

APPRAISER

Mark Kardone

(904) 710-4144

LAND SURVEYOR

On Point Land Surveyors

OPLS8102@gmail.com

COMING SOON

PREFERRED MORTGAGE LENDERS

COMING SOON

COMING SOON

COMING SOON

WHAT CLIENTS ARE SAYING

Trusted by Buyers & Sellers Across *Northeast Florida*

Real stories from real clients — because results speak louder than promises.

★★★★★

Mathew was wonderful. He was dedicated and hard working. We had a hiccup with the lender we were originally using and Mathew was able to refer us to another lender which fast-tracked our closing. He was knowledgeable and walked us through every step of the way. Our overall experience was wonderful — if we ever decide to sell or purchase another home, he will definitely be our first call!

Jessica
Bought in Callahan, FL · 2018
REALTOR.COM

★★★★★

Mathew went above and beyond in so many ways to get our house sold! He was always in communication with us while we were selling from out of state. He did more than any other realtor we have ever used — so professional, informative, proactive, and helpful. We could not have picked anyone better. He was the best realtor we have ever used, and we have sold and bought multiple homes over many years!

The Martins
November 2018
REALTOR.COM

★★★★★

Matt was so amazing during our first-time home buying experience. He was very quick to respond during the hunting phase all the way through closing — and has even helped us with several things since. He's knowledgeable about the area and construction, and has very reputable contacts for lending, inspections, appraisals, and more. Our VA renovation loan was complicated and Matt made it all happen. I cannot say enough great things.

Andy & Stacy
Bought in Saint Augustine, FL · 2019
ZILLOW

★★★★★

Matthew went far above and beyond to assist me in getting the house ready for sale. Since I live in another state, there were things I simply couldn't get done — he took it upon himself to make sure they were handled. He had a list of credible contractors who were reasonable and quick. In the end, the house sold for what we wanted, and reasonably quickly.

Michael Watson
Sold in Dinsmore, Jacksonville, FL · 2019
ZILLOW



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Your home. Your future. Let's find it together.

MATHEW
(904) 334-2295

EMAIL
904MattSmith@gmail.com

KHRISTI
me@khristivee.com

ADDRESS
1262-1 S McDuff Avenue
Jacksonville, FL 32205

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